DAY 35 | PRE-READ

Watching AI While It Works

A light read before Day 35. About 15 minutes, no code required.

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Why read this?

Once an AI system is live, you need to know how it is doing right now, and whether the world around it has changed. Tomorrow you build the instruments, spot drift, and automate the routine checks. It is the last teaching day before the capstone.

1. A car dashboard and a flight recorder

A car's dashboard shows speed, fuel and warning lights. A flight recorder lets investigators see exactly what happened. AI systems need both: a dashboard of requests, speed, errors, cost and user happiness, and logs and traces that record each request step by step.

Signal	Question it answers
Logs	What happened in this one request?
Metrics	How is the whole system doing?
Traces	Which step was slow, and how many tokens did it use?
Feedback	Are users getting good answers?

2. A common language for AI traces NEW (v4)

Electricians everywhere use the same colours for wires, so anyone can read a fuse box. **OpenTelemetry** gives AI traces the same kind of shared labels: which model, how many tokens in and out. Any monitoring tool can then read them, and you can add up the cost of one user question.

3. Maps go out of date

A city map from five years ago still looks correct, but new roads have opened. AI systems face the same problem, called **drift**: users ask new things, policies change, documents go stale, and sometimes the provider quietly updates the model behind the same name.

4. Let the schedule do the routine NEW (v4)

Checking for drift and re-running tests can happen automatically every night or week, through a pipeline schedule or a scheduled coding-agent task. People are alerted only when something needs attention.

Key idea: if you cannot see it, you cannot fix it. Instrument first, then improve one change at a time.

5. Preparing for the capstone

From tomorrow you work in teams on a five-day capstone project. Read the six project briefs tonight and choose your top two.

6. Think about these before class

- Which three numbers would you want on a dashboard for SmartDesk?
- How would you notice that users had started asking about something new?
- If an AI answer got longer every week, which number would show it first?

Ashiato (足跡): footprints, the trail left behind